IYHD Institute for Youth Health & Development

REFLECT ON YOU: BODY IMAGE AND SELF-ESTEEM

IMPACT FELLOWSHIP
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REFLECT ON YOU: BODY IMAGE AND SELF-ESTEEM

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Executive Summary

Studies have found that the rise in mental health conditions among youth may be linked to the parallel increase of social media use (Marchant et al., 2017; Pan & Yeh, 2018). Through exploring this relationship, researchers have made recommendations to better support youth by advocating for social policy reform and raising awareness in the community (Abi-Jaoude et al., 2020).

This report contributes to larger conversations about youth mental health. Campaigns such as #BellLetsTalk and organizations like Jack.org are helping increase mental health awareness. However, many stereotypes and generalizations continue to paint an inaccurate picture of youth mental health.

The purpose of this research project was to dive deeper into the topic of youth mental health. By focusing specifically on body image and self-esteem, the effects of these factors on daily activities, thoughts, and attitudes of young people were explored.

Using an anonymous online survey that was distributed on social media, in schools, and across youth networks, a total of 173 responses from young people aged 14-18 living in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA) was gathered. The survey included a combination of qualitative and quantitative questions.

The results are organized into the five key areas that we explored in connection to body image and self-esteem:

- Age
- Social Media
- Support Systems and Relationships
- Identity and Self-Expression
- School

The findings in these key areas bring nuance to the understandings of adolescent body-image and self-esteem. It is clear that environmental and structural factors, such as relationships and identity, are equally influential on one's sense of self as individual-level thoughts and behaviours. Therefore, strategies to improve body image and self-esteem require much more than practicing daily affirmations and a positive mindset.

About Us



2020 Youth Research Fellows

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- Yogya, Grade 09
- Hanan, Grade 10
- Analpa, Grade 11
- Britney, Grade 11
- Heather, Grade 11
- Saima, Grade 11
- Sylvie, Grade 11
- Michelle, Grade 12
- Annona, First Year, Ryerson University

BACKGROUND

As youth, issues we face are often dismissed. Being a teen can feel like the ultimate balancing act, struggling to juggle a million different things at once. We are attempting to discover who we are, all while being bombarded with school life, social media, friendships, and relationships. Not to mention, on top of this, trying to understand our ever-changing world and the role we play in it. Therefore, the Institute for Youth Health and Development (IYHD) was created with the goal of informing and improving the lives of youth in the GTA and beyond.

The IYHD was founded in 2018 by a group of Toronto-based young adults. Under the premise that young people have the power to understand their own experiences and needs, the IYHD provides opportunities for teens in Toronto to engage in research and advocacy on health topics that matter most to them.

The IMPACT Fellowship is an annual program in which high school students from across the GTA deliver a youth participatory action research (YPAR) project. By using collaborative research methods to identify areas for social change, the Youth Research Fellows reveal insights that may otherwise be overlooked.

In 2017, researchers at Toronto's Centre for Addiction and Mental Health found that 39% of teenagers within Ontario were reporting moderate to serious mental health issues, revealing a 15% increase from 2013. Moreover, the proportion of Ontario's teenagers spending 5 or more hours a day on social media increased from 11% in 2013 to 20% in 2017 (Boak et al., 2018). Although researchers are currently still exploring the relationship between social media usage and mental health, there is a fundamental understanding that mental health distress within teenagers is a growing epidemic that has not been adequately addressed.

Many academic studies evaluating the factors that affect youth mental health have been published, however research from a community-based approach has yet to be done, specifically in Toronto. YPAR allows for empowering youth communities and developing relationships. It is our goal that these aspects can build on the basis for effective mental health care and prevention at both the community and system level.

With this being said, this year's initiative, *Reflect On You: Body Image and Self-Esteem*, sheds light on factors influencing teen body image and self-esteem in the GTA. Our team created and conducted a survey, then compiled the findings shared in this report. This process challenged us, surprised us, and sparked personal reflection and growth.

METHODOLOGY

Our inquiry was based in Participatory Action Research (PAR).

We understand PAR to differ from traditional research in three main ways:

- research subjects are partners in delivering every aspect of the research project, with a close attention paid to power imbalances,
- researchers are encouraged to bring their own experiences and biases to the process,
- the research process emphasizes social action.

What did we do?



Figure 2. Youth researchers discuss the process of PAR and what it means to them.

Following five sessions focused on community building, PAR training, and group discussions about body image and self-esteem, we created a short survey using Google Forms.

Responses were gathered from Thursday, February 28, 2020 to Thursday, March 12, 2020 through social media outreach in various youth networks and schools. While the survey itself was anonymous, respondents had the opportunity to share their email for the chance to win one of five gift cards.

A total of 193 responses were gathered. Since our target population was high school students aged 14-18 living in the GTA, respondents outside of these conditions were removed from the dataset. The final dataset included 173 responses.

In addition to compiling our data analysis in this report, we have created a Zine. The Zine is a creative expression of our learning, and includes photography, poetry, illustrations, and reflections about youth health.

DEMOGRAPHICS

A. AGE

Of the 173 youth who responded to the survey, the mean age was 16 years old. The majority of the youth were 16 years old (49%), while the least represented age group was 18 year olds (3%).

Table 1. Profile of youth respondents (N=173).

Demographic Variables	*N*	Percent (%)	Mean
Total	173		
Age			16
14	24	14	
15	21	12	
16	85	49	
17	37	21	
18	6	3.5	
Gender			
Male	48	28	
Female	120	69	
Prefer Not To Say	5	2.9	
Sexual Orientation			
Heterosexual	146	84	
Homosexual	5	2.9	
Bisexual	14	8.1	
Pansexual	4	2.3	
Demisexual	1	0.58	
Asexual	1	0.58	
Graysexual	1	0.58	
Prefer Not To Say	1	0.58	
Religious			
Yes	82	47	
No	54	31	
Unsure	37	21	

B. GENDER

Respondents were 69% female, 28% male, and 3% preferred not to say.

C. RELIGION

When asked about religion, 47% of youth identified as religious, 31% identified as non-religious, and 21% were unsure

D. SEXUAL ORIENTATION

A majority, 84%, of youth whom responded to the survey identified as heterosexual.

E. ETHNICITY

Respondents were asked to self-identify their ethnicity. Of the respondents, 36% identified as South Asian and 24% identified as East Asian.

RESULTS

1. Age

1.1 AGE vs. POSITIVITY ABOUT THE FUTURE

HYPOTHESIS:

In our own experience as high school students, we observe that older students generally appear more confident. When designing this research project, we hypothesized that age would positively correlate with self-esteem.

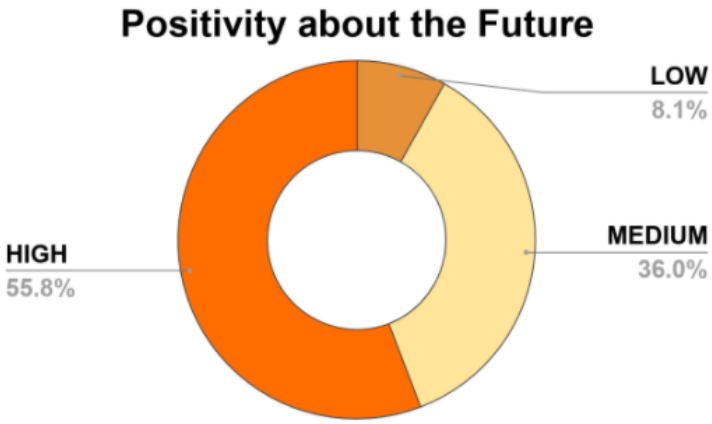


Figure 1. Respondents by positivity about the future (N=173).

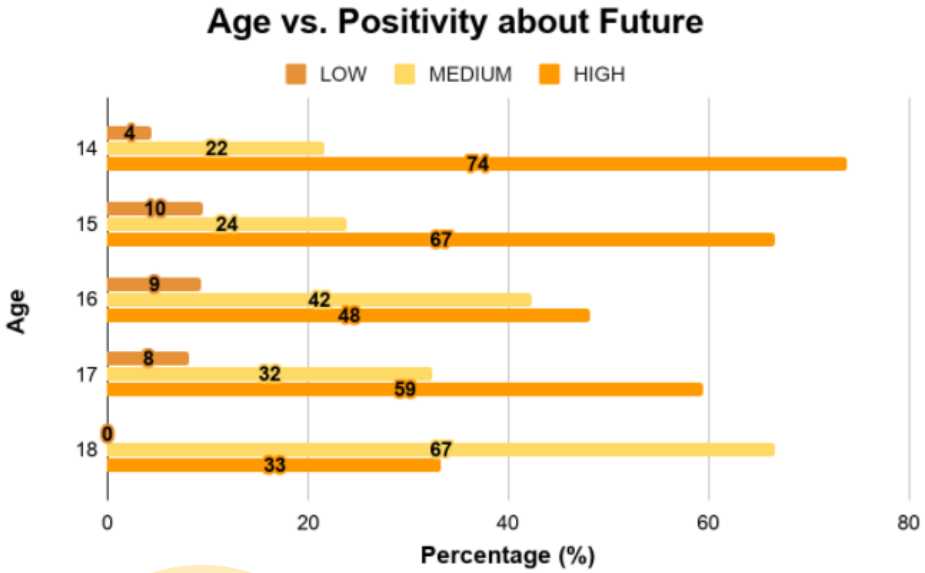


Figure 2. Age vs. positivity about the future.

Our results do not suggest any trend between age and the state of one's body image or self-esteem.

Overall, 55% of all the respondents reported feelings of high positivity towards the future.

Aside from the 18-year old youth group, this was also seen once data was disaggregated by age. Contrary to our hypothesis,

the 18-year old respondents reported feeling less positive than their younger counterparts.

The lack of positivity expressed by the older students may be due to the fact that this age group is transitioning from high-school to post-secondary. This is often a period of uncertainty and can be very stressful. Increased pressure to make decisions about their future after high school can likely lead to less positivity about the future and a decrease in self-esteem.

2. Social Media

For the purpose of this study, gender minorities were defined as females and those whom did not identify as cis-males.

HYPOTHESIS:

From our experiences, gender minorities are underrepresented in mainstream media and on social media platforms. Thus, we hypothesized that gender minorities would report having a more negative experience on social media compared to males.

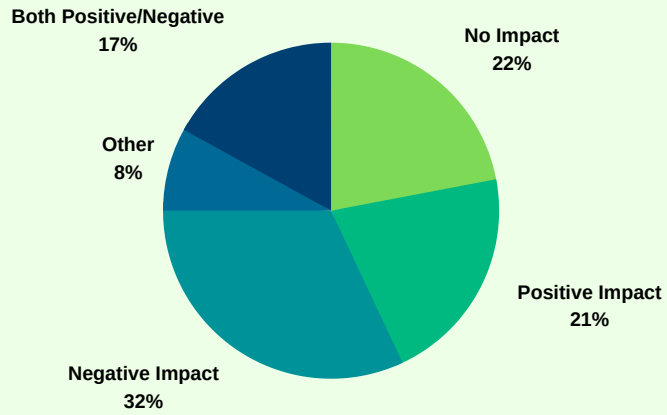


Figure 3. Respondents on impact of social media (N=173).

2.1 SOCIAL MEDIA vs. GENDER

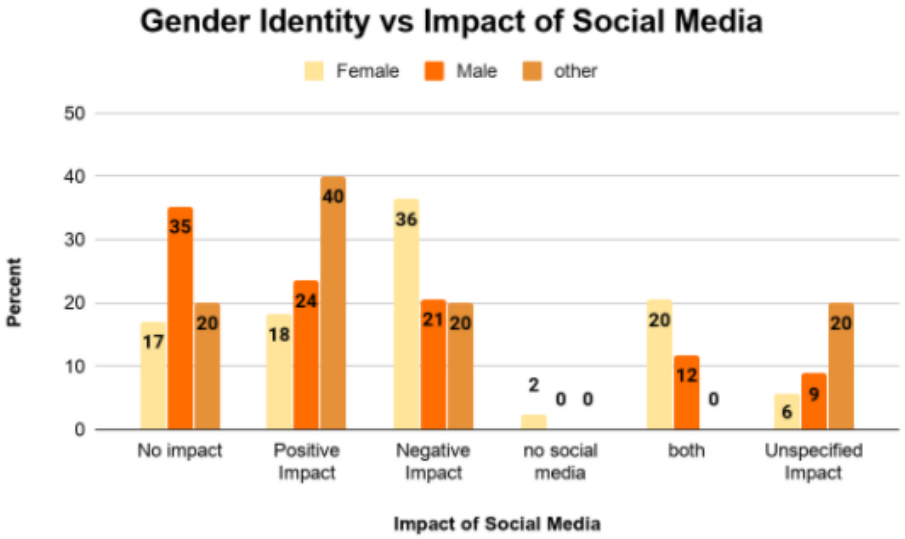


Figure 4. Gender vs. impact of social media.

The quantitative data did not suggest that social media has an overarching positive nor negative impact on body image and self-esteem.

However, as hypothesized, we noticed gendered differences. Gender minorities seemed to have a more negative opinion about social media. The data revealed that a larger proportion of youth identifying as females compared to other gender identities expressed that social media has a negative impact on their self-esteem.

Of the youth identifying as females, 36% reported that social media had a negative impact on self-esteem, compared to 21% of the males and 20% of other identified genders. Male respondents were more likely to believe that social media has no impact on their self-esteem. Respondents who identify as neither female nor male were far more likely to indicate that social media has a positive impact on their self-esteem.

2.2 SOCIAL MEDIA vs. SELF-ESTEEM

The qualitative findings provided a better understanding of how youth perceive social media to impact them. When asked to explain how social media impacts them, respondents, largely females, revealed that they often felt that they were comparing themselves to others on social media which created negative feelings. The lack of body positivity, inaccurate portrayals of happiness and success, along with feeling excluded from peers were topics that youth brought up. However, contrary to the impression that teenagers are too young to understand the consequences of the negative impacts social media may have, a majority of the youth surveyed were very cognisant to the idea that social media can be both positive and negative, depending on how it is used. In fact, some youth even claimed to have deleted social media when they felt it was overwhelming them with negative feelings.

"Social media tends to usually impact my personal self-esteem in various ways. I have mainly been impacted in a positive way as I am able to post and see things I am interested in which usually helps me view my profile from another point of view. This helps me remember and recognize who I am."

(GTA Female Youth Respondent)

Social media is able to make any individual anxious, even those who are positive about their future, comfortable in trying new things, and seem to have higher self esteems. It is difficult to maintain high levels of confidence while utilizing social media as it may continue to convince users that what they are doing in their personal lives is not enough. One common trend seen was that positive self image correlated closely with a peaceful relationship with social media. These youth expressed that social media also allowed for a safe, supportive, and creative space. They seemed to understand both the positive and negative effects of social media, but had made some peace with them. The inverse was generally true as well, with negative self talk often creating a toxic relationship with social media.

Therefore, the effects social media can have on oneself highly depends on the usage of social media. Individuals must be self-aware when it is becoming too much for their mental health and everyday lives and decide to take breaks. Instead of trying to force youth to decrease their social media time, it is thus more impactful to remind youth that they have control over what is seen and how it affects them emotionally.

"Social media positively impacts my self esteem because i know that if I am too scared to talk about my insecurities to someone in person, i can talk to them over social media and people are more honest over a screen." (GTA Female Youth Respondent)

"Social media impacts my self esteem negatively and positively. Sometimes I find myself looking at pictures with girls with a skinny waist or long hair and it almost makes me feel as if that what I need to look like to fit in. Although there's many negative things about social media I'd say some of the pages help me to feel beautiful such as skincare threads, positive quotes, pep talks, (etc.). " (GTA Female Youth Respondent)

"Social media has both positive and negative impacts on my self esteem. It tells me that I should love who I am inside and out, but it also tells me that I am not perfect, I don't have the perfect body, I don't look good without makeup and etc. Although, I genuinely don't care for what others have to say, I know that I have my own goals physically, emotionally and mentally and as long as I just make me happy then that's all that matters. I'm comfortable in my own skin, just not a huge social butterfly; I'm really shy but, I can fix that with time, it's honestly getting better though, so I don't worry about it much." (GTA Female Youth Respondent)

"I feel like I surround myself with better social media outlets than others. I don't follow celebrities because I know that doing so will contribute to the deterioration of my mental health. Right now, I only follow friends and family, meme accounts, and mental health reminder accounts. So, overall, I think social media has a more positive impact on my mental health." (GTA Female Youth Respondent)

"Yes it does impact me in both ways. It negative as sometimes it makes me want to live a life style that celebrities do even when I know that there's much more they don't post. It's positive when I see people helping others and working as a one to make it a positive space." (GTA Male Youth Respondent)

"It doesn't affect my personal self esteem. While I spend a lot of time on social media, I don't take a lot of what I see to heart. Someone online that I don't know doesn't know anything about me from the limited interactions I have on social media, and the people that do know me aren't negative people, we mostly just use social media as a platform to contact each other and share things we like." (GTA Female Youth Respondent)

3. Support Systems

3.1 SUPPORT SYSTEMS vs. POSITIVITY ABOUT THE FUTURE

The results of this project demonstrate the importance of having supportive relationships with peers and adults. Although a majority of youth said that they had more than one adult they could trust in their life, it was highly concerning that 20% of respondents stated they did not have, or were unsure, if they had a single adult in their life that they could trust and rely on. In fact, 57% of youth reported having two or less support systems.

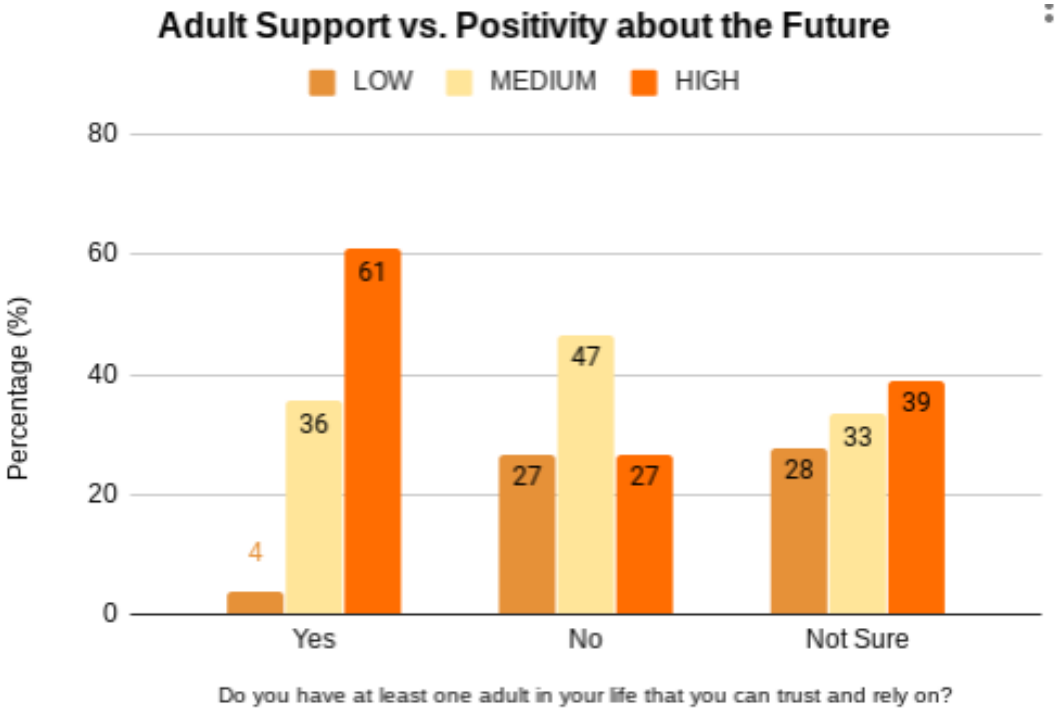


Figure 5. Adult support vs positivity about the future. The graph shows that of those who reported that they are unsure about adult support, only 39% said they feel positive about the future. This shows strong but not absolute direct correlation between the two variables.

As we predicted, respondents who reported having a supportive adult in their life were far more likely to feel positive about the future. Of the youth with no adult support present in their lives, 27% reported high levels of positivity about the future. Conversely, of the respondents with at least one adult support present, 61% stated high levels of positivity.

As a youth, having a trusting adult to confide in is very comforting. During this time of uncertainty, reassurance and guidance by elders may allow for more confidence about the future. We also chose to explore how having support systems may affect youth and their resiliency. Resiliency was defined as being able to try again after failing.

3.2 SUPPORT SYSTEMS vs. RESILIENCY

Interestingly, the data revealed that there was no trend or difference in feelings of resiliency when comparing youth who had at least one adult they could trust and youth who did not have such an adult figure. In both groups, a majority reported they were likely to try something again after failing the first time. However, of those who were unsure of whether they had an adult they could trust, only 39% reported feeling confident enough to try again after failing.

This may suggest that due to the uncertainty and potential lack of stability in having a trustworthy adult present can contribute to youth having feelings of doubt and less confidence. Whereas, those who are aware of the fact that they do not have a trusting relationship with any adult figure in their life, may have been forced to mature and be more resilient earlier on in life compared to their peers.

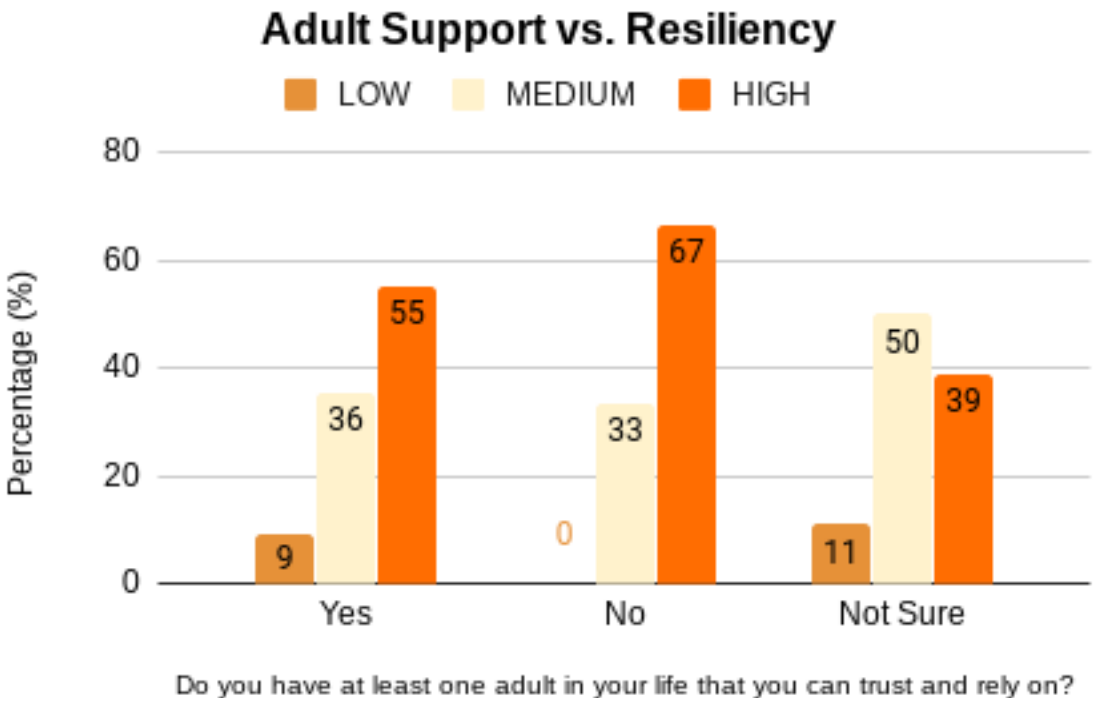


Figure 6. Adult support vs resiliency.

4. Identity

4.1 IDENTITY vs. POSITIVITY ABOUT THE FUTURE

HYPOTHESIS:

The more one feels their identity falls within social norms, the more positive they would feel about the future.

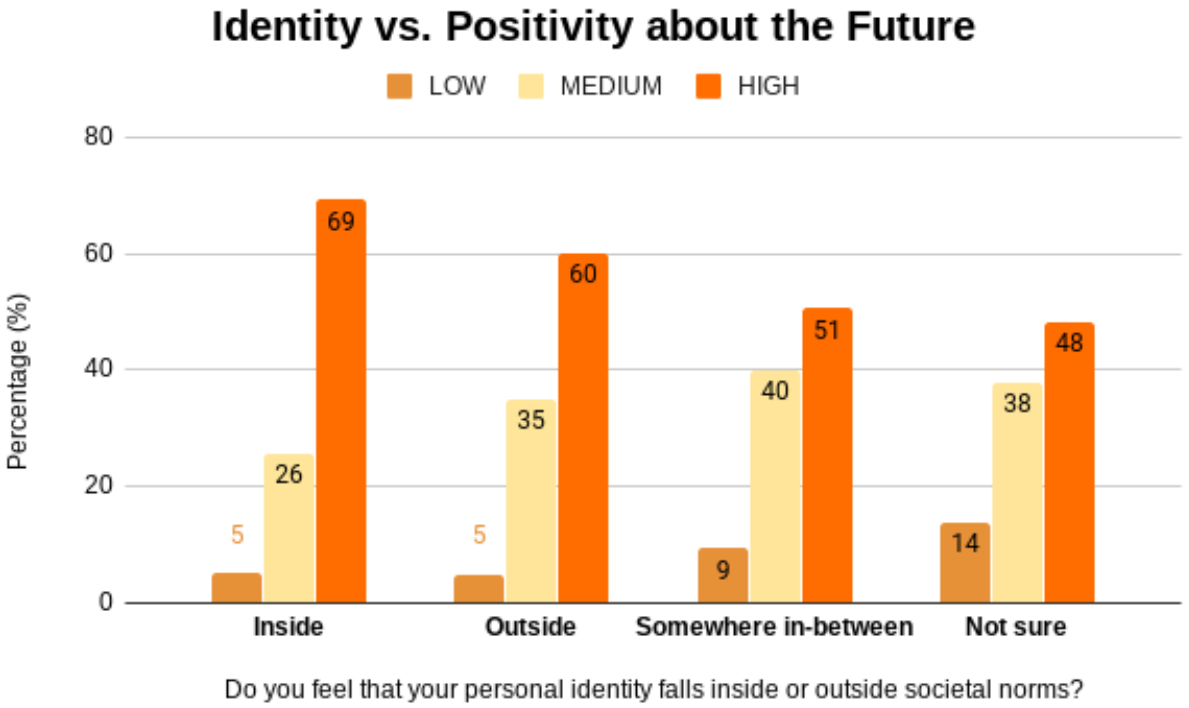


Figure 7. Identity vs positivity about the future reflects how respondents perceived their own identities vs how positive they felt about the future.

We hypothesized that the more one feels their identity falls within social norms, the more positive they would feel about the future. The definition of societal norms was subjective based on the respondent's interpretation. Of all the youth surveyed, almost 50% reported that their personal identity fell somewhere in between and outside social norms. This graph explores the proportion of youth whom are positive about the future based on their perceived identities. Of the youth who identify within societal norms, 69% were more likely to feel positive than negative about the future. This may suggest that feeling accepted and included by society can also lead to beliefs that a larger support group will always exist to encourage you throughout life, which in turn creates higher feelings of positivity about the future.

5. School

5.1 SCHOOL vs. POSITIVITY ABOUT THE FUTURE

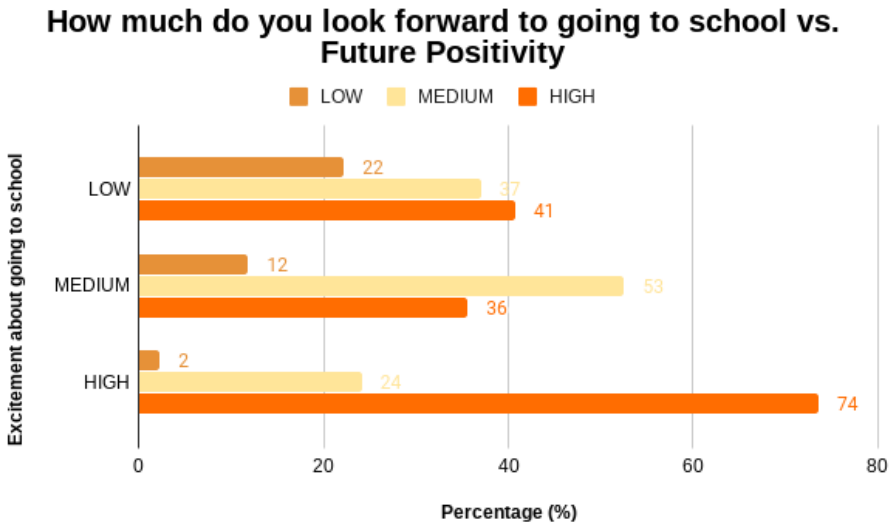


Figure 8. Levels of positivity about the future reported by respondents in relation to how much they looked forward to going to school.

We believed that a larger proportion of youth reporting excitement about going to school would also have higher feelings of positivity about the future compared to their peers. In total, 50% of the youth respondents reported feeling very excited about going to school. However, as we expected, more of these youth, 74%, were also highly positive about their future compared to their peers. Of the individuals reporting low levels of excitement about school, only 41% felt positive about their future. From our experiences as youth, society puts an immense pressure on us to go to school and get good grades. We are taught that going to school assures a happier and more secure future. Thus, those who are excited about going to school may have internalized these beliefs and feel more confident about their future. Moreover, not feeling excited about going to school may not be completely attributed to the academic portion of our education system. It is also likely that this lack of excitement is rooted in the socializing aspect of school and struggling to feel accepted by peers. As a teenager, feeling included and having friends are extremely important. Thus, not feeling comfortable socially at school can limit the ability to be excited about going to school, regardless of academic success. This, in turn, can largely affect self-esteem and confidence about one's future, which can largely impact mental health overall.

LIMITATIONS

We acknowledge and believe that it is important to address the limitations we encountered, which may have impacted our results and conclusions. These limitations can be summarized as follows:

1. AGE
The age distribution of youth who responded to the survey was uneven. With the mean age of 16, the 18 year olds were underrepresented.

2. GENDER
The gender distribution was also uneven, with respondents who self identified as women exceeding any other demographic.

3. ETHNICITIES
Finally, the generalizations made are limited to the ethnic backgrounds of the respondents. As not all ethinic backgrounds were equally represented, the conclusions are subject to limitation.

CONCLUSION

In order to continue supporting youth mental health, it is important to understand the various factors that particularly affect young people today. This report sheds light on how body image and self-esteem influence the daily activities, thoughts, and attitudes of young people. Our results also highlight how the conversation needs to shift to a focus on how can we maintain social media as a tool and less about how often youth should be using it.

It is clear from our findings that social media remains a part of teenagers' daily lives. When trying to determine the reason for poor mental health involving low feelings of self-esteem, it would be more beneficial to further examine youth and their interaction with environmental factors such as support systems along with navigating how one self-identifies, and how these factors interact with social media use.

Social media can be a valuable tool to meaningfully connect with others. However, the underlying profit model of social media converts websites and apps from being more than just a tool to an addictive habit. With toxic unregulated content available online to everyone, including youth, comes the negative side effects we are witnessing in youth mental health. It is the responsibility of our government to create appropriate regulations to meet the needs of youth and contribute to making social media safer for our communities to engage with.



Figure 9. Youth researchers learn about PAR.



Figure 10. Some of the youth research fellows' beautiful smiles.

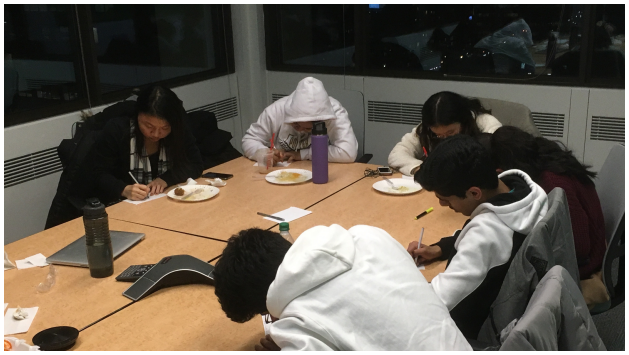


Figure 11. Youth researchers reflect about body image and self-esteem.

"As a recent university grad, it's super inspiring to hear you all speak on so many deep societal and cultural issues and bring a whole different perspective to them. It's amazing knowing that our youths are in such great hands like yourselves. Keep advocating for what you believe in, all your hard work is incredible."
(Webinar Participant)



Figure 12. Team picture after the webinar event.

"I'm sitting here feeling amazed, humbled, and grateful for all the work, time, and effort you have all put into this incredible initiative - especially through these challenging circumstances. You have made room for difficult, but such important conversations to be had - conversations that are often pushed to the side. This team deserves a HUGE congratulations and I hope that you all CONTINUE with this powerful work. Thank you - truly, thank you to each and every one of you!"
(Webinar Participant)

This study was an invaluable experience for us as youth researchers. Not only because it allowed us to gain a deeper insight into the factors that influence self-esteem, but it also helped us clarify pre-existing notions that society promotes.

It was very informative to also actively engage with peers in our community through our online webinar. Our original plan was to plan an in-person event, however due to COVID-19, we adapted and hosted a virtual knowledge-sharing event on May 29, 2020. We were able to engage over 45 community members, including other high school youth, nurses, teachers, medical and law students, and policymakers. Being able to share our results and have further discussions about how we, as youth, can work together to combat the issue of rising mental health problems.

We feel equipped with a deeper knowledge and understanding of the influences on youth self-esteem in the GTA. These findings are invaluable to inform prevention strategies necessary to address mental health concerns among youth.

"Thank you for all the effort everyone put into this. As an educator, this was so inspiring. Our youth will definitely change the world!"
(Webinar Participant)

Acknowledgements

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APPENDIX A

SURVEY

Body Image and Self-Esteem Survey

As youth researchers at the Institute of Youth Health and Development (IYHD), we aim to improve the health of fellow youth in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA) through participatory action research. This research style allows us to delve deeper into problems that plague our youth community and find realistic solutions that can be applied in our world today.

The purpose of this survey is to gain a greater understanding of how body image and self-esteem affect our youth.

Please take a few minutes to fill out this anonymous survey, all responses will be kept confidential.

As a token for your participation, you may enter your email at the end of the survey for a chance to win one of eight $15 gift cards to Cineplex.

For further information, please contact info@iyhd.ca

Thank you!

Institute for Youth Health and Development
w. www.iyhd.ca
e. info@iyhd.ca
@IYHDToronto / @6ixYouth
* Required

1. What is your age? *

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ 14
- ◯ 15
- ◯ 16
- ◯ 17
- ◯ 18
- ◯ Other: _____

2. Do you live in the Greater Toronto Area? *

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No
- ◯ Not sure

3. What is your ethnicity? *

_____

4. What is your gender identity?

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Female
- ◯ Male
- ◯ Transgender
- ◯ Two Spirit
- ◯ Non Binary
- ◯ Gender Fluid
- ◯ Unsure
- ◯ Prefer not to say
- ◯ Other: _____

5. What is your sexual orientation? *

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Heterosexual (attracted to the opposite sex)
- ◯ Homosexual (attracted to the same sex)
- ◯ Bisexual (attracted to male and female genders)
- ◯ Asexual (does not experience sexual attraction)
- ◯ Pansexual (attraction regardless of biological sex, gender, or identity)
- ◯ Other: _____

6. Do you consider yourself to be religious? *

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No
- ◯ Unsure
- ◯ Other: _____

7. How much do you generally look forward to going to school? *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
I never look forward to going to school	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	I always look forward to going to school

8. Do you have at least one adult in your life that you trust and can rely on?

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No
- ◯ Not sure

16. How comfortable do you feel when trying new things? *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Very uncomfortable	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Very comfortable

17. How likely are you to try something again after you fail the first time? *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Very unlikely	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Very likely

18. "I can usually achieve my goals if I work hard towards reaching them." *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Strongly disagree	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Strongly agree

19. Does social media impact (positively and/or negatively) your personal self-esteem? If so, how? (1-4 sentences)

20. Do you feel that your personal identity/identities tend to fall more inside or outside societal norms? *

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Inside
- ◯ Outside
- ◯ Somewhere in-between
- ◯ Not sure

Thank you for participating!

The information provided in this section will not be linked to your previous responses.

21. For the chance to win one of eight $15 gift cards to Cineplex, please provide your email below!

9. How content do you feel about your academic performance? *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
I am unhappy with my academic performance	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	I am very happy with my academ

10. How comfortable are you expressing yourself in social settings with people you don't know?

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Very uncomfortable	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Very comfortable

11. How comfortable do you feel about your physical appearance? *

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
I'm very uncomfortable with my physical appearance	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	I'm very comfortable witl

12. Which of the following support systems are present in your life right now? *

Check all that apply.

- ☐ Family
- ☐ Friends
- ☐ Teachers/School Staff (e.g. Guidance Counsellor)
- ☐ Adult Mentors
- ☐ Religious Leaders

Other: ☐ _____

13. What are three words that best describe yourself? *

_____

14. What are three words that you think others would use to describe you? *

_____

15. How positive do you feel about your future?

Mark only one oval.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Not positive at all	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Very positive



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